



# THE DESIGNER'S PROBLEM

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An erroneous conception of the graphic designer's function is to imagine that in order to produce a "good layout" all he need do is make a pleasing arrangement of miscellaneous elements. What is implied is that this may be accomplished simply by pushing these elements around, until something happens. At best, this procedure involves the time-consuming uncertainties of trial and error, and at worst, an indifference to plan, order, or discipline.

The designer does not, as a rule, begin with some preconceived idea. Rather, the idea is (or should be) the result of careful study and observation, and the design a product of that idea. In order, therefore, to achieve an effective solution to his problem, the designer must necessarily go through some sort of mental process. Consciously or not, he analyzes, interprets, formulates. He is aware of the scientific and technological developments in his own and kindred fields. He improvises, invents, or discovers new techniques and combinations. He co-ordinates and integrates his material so that he may restate his problem in terms of ideas, signs, symbols, pictures. He unifies, simplifies, and eliminates superfluities. He symbolizes abstracts from his material by association and analogy. He intensifies and reinforces his symbol with appropriate accessories to

achieve clarity and interest.

He draws upon instinct and intuition. He considers the spectator, his feelings and predilections.

The designer is primarily confronted with three classes of material: a) the given material: product, copy, slogan, logotype, format, media, production process; b) the formal material: space, contrast, proportion, harmony, rhythm, repetition, line, mass, shape, color, weight, volume, value, texture; c) the psychological material: visual perception and optical illusion problems, the spectators' instincts, intuitions, and emotions as well as the designer's own needs.

As the material furnished him is often inadequate, vague, uninteresting, or otherwise unsuitable for visual interpretation, the designer's task is to re-create or restate the problem. This may involve discarding or revising much of the given material. By analysis (breaking down of the complex material into its simplest components...the how, why, when, and where) the designer is able to begin to state the problem.

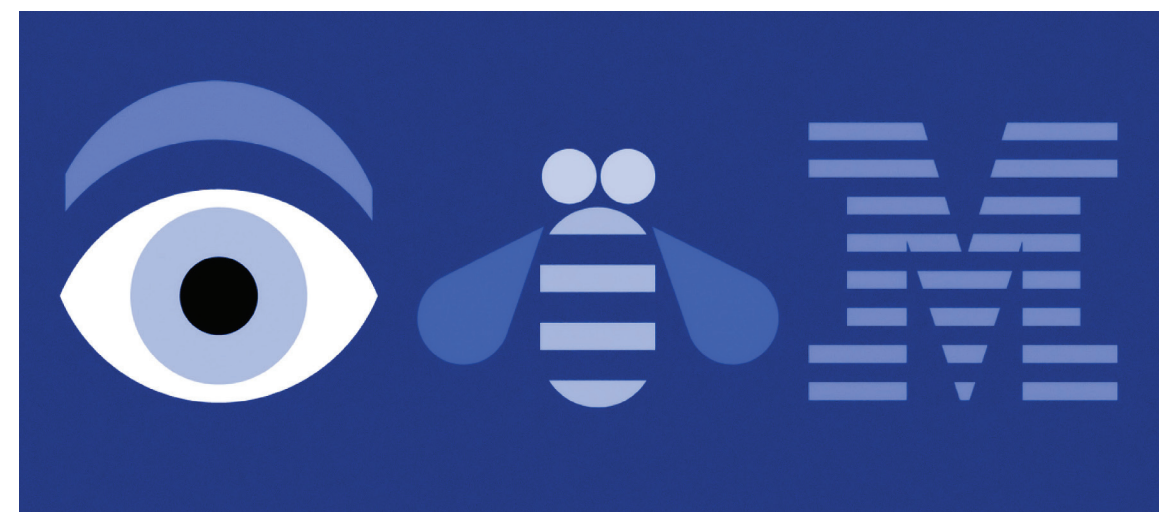




NeXT Computers  
1986



Conneticut Art  
Director's Club  
1986



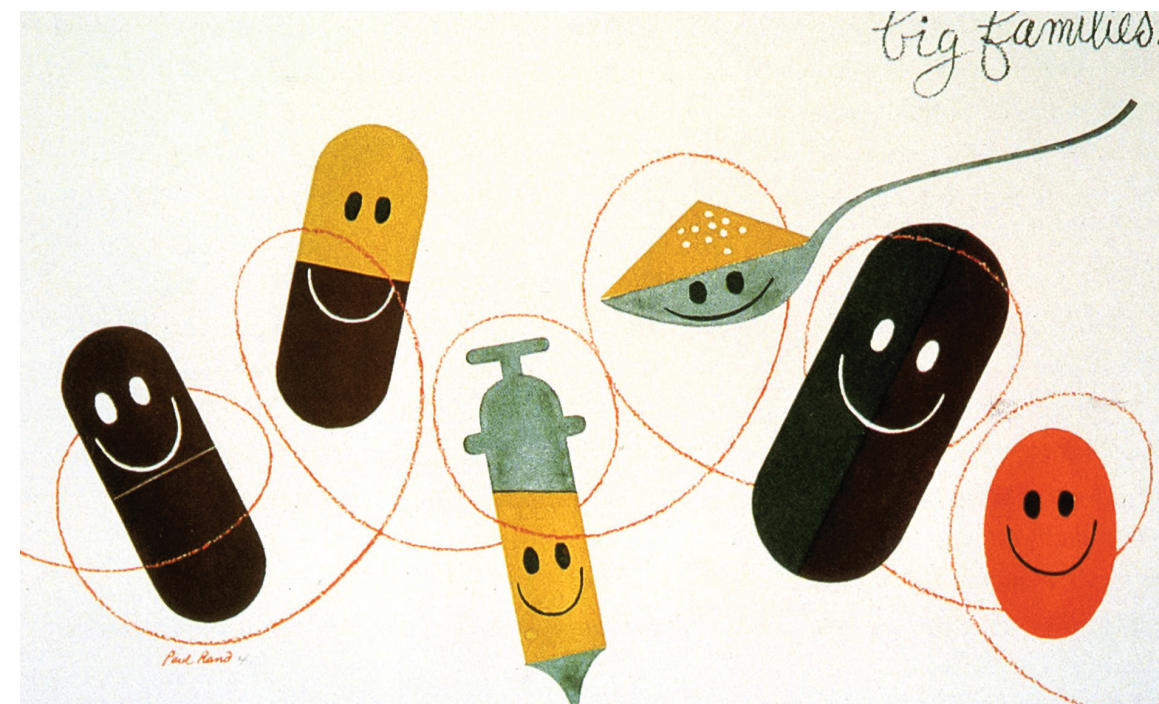
Eye-Bee-M (IBM) - 1981



AIGA  
1982



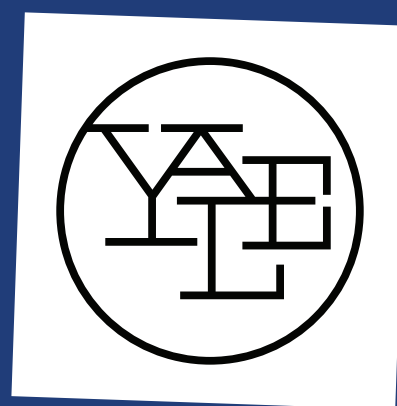
UPS  
1961



Pharmaceutical Ad - 1947



Westinghouse  
(unknown)



Yale University  
1985

